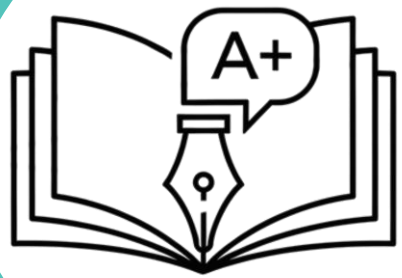

CITATION STYLES

Objectives

01 distinguish the difference between APA and MLA formatting,

02 construct an accurate bibliographic entry for both APA and MLA styles, and

03 value the importance of academic integrity by consistently citing sources correctly within a research paper.

WHAT IS PLAGIARISM?

The English Oxford Living Dictionaries has defined plagiarism as the act of taking someone else's work, ideas, or intellectual property and presenting them as your own. In both academic and professional environments, this is classified as academic misconduct, a serious offense associated with labels like "stealing," "piracy," and "copyright infringement." Whether it involves "cribbing" or "library theft," these unfavorable terms represent a significant stain on one's reputation and integrity.

A citation serves as a formal acknowledgment that specific information in your work originates from an external source. It provides readers with the essential metadata required to locate the original material, including the author's name, the title of the work, and publication details such as the company, date, and specific page numbers. By including these elements, a citation not only credits the original creator but also establishes the credibility and transparency of your own research.

Citing Sources

Citation Styles

While citation styles vary across academic disciplines to suit specific rhetorical needs, they all share the common goal of organizing source information within the text and the final reference list. These styles differ slightly in their formatting of in-text citations and bibliographic entries to distinguish between different fields of study.

Citation Style	Academic discipline
APA	Psychology, Education, Hotel and Restaurant Management, Business, Economics, and other Social Sciences
MLA	Literature, Arts, and Humanities
IEEE	Engineering
AMA	Medicine, Health, and Natural Sciences
Chicago	Reference books, non-academic, periodicals (e.g. newspapers, magazines, journals)

APA CITATION

Format

This system relies on a "who, when, what, and where" formula to credit sources, requiring specific details like the author's name, publication date, title, and source location (such as a publisher or URL).

In an APA-formatted paper, sources are credited using in-text parenthetical citations, which correspond to a final References list of cited works. If a writer chooses to include every resource consulted—even those not directly quoted—a supplemental Bibliography page is used to provide a comprehensive overview of the research process.

Reference List

To properly conclude your paper, always begin your list of sources on a fresh page. The title References should be centered at the top to identify the works specifically cited in your text. However, if your instructor requires a Bibliography instead, you must include every resource you consulted during your research process, regardless of whether you directly referenced them in your writing.

Listing	Arrange the list alphabetically by the author's surname, followed by his/her initials.
One author, several works	For several works written by the same author, arrange the year of publication starting with the most recent.
Several authors, one publication	If a publication has more than seven auhors, list the first six authors followed by an ellipsis (…), then the last author's name without using the customary ampersand (&).
Spacing	Double-space all entries.

Reference List

Capitalization	Capitalize proper names and the first word in each title, and the first word after a colon or dash.
Indentation	Use hanging indent- flush left margin for the first time, then indent the second and suceeding lines five spaces from the left.

Electronic Sources

The APA style for citing electronic sources follows a logical "who, what, when, and where" structure, prioritizing the use of a Digital Object Identifier (DOI) for accuracy. When a DOI is available, it serves as the complete retrieval record, eliminating the need for a URL or retrieval date. However, if no DOI exists, you must provide the source's URL—preceded by "Retrieved from"—along with the document title, publication date (or "n.d." if unavailable), and author name. Because online content is subject to change or removal, including the exact retrieval date is crucial for traceability, and sources without an author should be alphabetized by their title instead.

Electronic Sources

E-book (Version of print book):

Conrad, J. (2000). The heart of darkness. [Ebooks.com Reader version]. Retrieved from https://www.ebooks.com/340583/heart-of-darkness/conrad-joseph/

E-book (No printed version):

Eden, C. (n.d.) Bound by blood. Retrieved from https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/11042027-bound-by-blood

Online Journal with DOI:

Emmanuel, R. (2011). Critical concerns for oral communication education in Alabama and beyond. Education Research International, 5(1), 67-73. http://dx.doi.org/10.1155/2011/948138

Online Newspaper (No author):

English and Philippine education. (2013). Retrieved from americanenglish.ph/english-and-philippine-education-the-good-and-the-bad/

Electronic Sources

Social Media & Other Sources

Blog:

Hunt, G. (2017, December 19). Creating your ideal family culture. [Web log post]. Retrieved from http://www.commonsenseethics.com/blog

Facebook:

Ubaña, M. (2018, January 27) Wherever life plants you, bloom with grace. [Facebook post]. https://web.facebook.com/marieallenubaña/posts/1OTQ1ODI3

YouTube:

Nishi, N. (2016, June 29). Concept paper. Retrieved from https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zOmW8Glx90

X

Tyson, N. D. [@neiltyson]. (2024, May 15). *The good thing about science is that it's true whether or not you believe in it. Happy studying everyone! #Science* [Post]. X.

In text citation

In the APA format, in-text citations follow a specific author-date-page sequence, with the exact placement of these details depending on the structure of your sentence. To properly format these citations, items within the parentheses must be separated by commas, and page numbers should be preceded by the abbreviation "p." for a single page or "pp." for multiple pages.

Examples:

Marquez (2016, p. 35) cites the advantage of e-books over traditional books.

Marquez (2016) cites the advantage of e-books over traditional books, claiming that "portability and manipulability are key features of e-books" (p.35).

MLA CITATION

Format

The Modern Language Association (MLA) style is the standard citation format for the Literature, Arts, and Humanities. While it shares the practice of alphabetizing authors with APA style, it has distinct mechanical differences, most notably requiring the author's full name rather than just initials. For both print and digital sources, the reference list follows a "who, what, where, and when" sequence. All borrowed materials, including diagrams and paraphrased text, must be documented in a final list titled "Works Cited".

Format

Listing	Author's surname appears first.
One author, several works	Alphabetize the works and use three hyphens to signify the author's name for every work after the first.
Several authors, one publication	Use the surname of the first author then continue listing the rest of the authors' names.
Works with no authors	Use the title of the work and alphabetize. Titles of books, magazines, journals, films, newspapers should be italicized.
Spacing	Double-space the Works Cited list.
Capitalization	Each word except conjunctions (and, by) and articles (a, an, the) should be capitalized.
Indentation	Use the hanging indent.

Format

The Modern Language Association (MLA) style is the standard citation format for the Literature, Arts, and Humanities. While it shares the practice of alphabetizing authors with APA style, it has distinct mechanical differences, most notably requiring the author's full name rather than just initials. For both print and digital sources, the reference list follows a "who, what, where, and when" sequence. All borrowed materials, including diagrams and paraphrased text, must be documented in a final list titled "Works Cited".

Example

For a Book:

Last Name, First Name. Title of Book. Publisher, Publication Date.

Example:

Wordsworth, William. Lyrical Ballads. Oxford UP, 1967.

For a Journal Article:

Author(s). "Title of Article." Title of Journal, vol. #, no. #, Date, pp. page range.

Example:

Belton, John. "Painting by the Numbers." Film Quarterly, vol. 61, no. 3, 2008, pp. 58-65.

In text citation

When you use the MLA style, you also include parenthetical documentation or in-text citation in appropriate places within your paper. In-text citations using the MLA format follow the author's name and page number format, but the word page may be omitted in the citation. In addition, a comma is not used to separate the information. Take note of the following examples:

Only 15 percent of the respondents prefer traditional books (Marquez 13).

According to Marquez, only 15 percent of the respondents prefer traditional books (13).

APA vs. MLA

Type	APA citation style	MLA citation style
Title for reference listing	"References"	"Works Cited"
Capitalization	Only the first letter of the title of the work is capitalized.	Proper names, first word of title, and first word appearing after a colon or semicolon are capitalized.
Abstract	Required	Not required
Headings in Main Body	Has headings to indicate important sections (e.g. "Method" or "Results")	No such headings.